

December 2, 1959

From: Superintendent's Office

To: _____

Re: Pre-School English Program

[encl. - 2 Dec 1959]

- I. Purpose: To carry on an intensive oral language program, speaking and understanding, which will enable non-English speaking students to enter the first grade and make normal progress, qualifying for the second grade after one year of intensive first grade instruction. An effective vocabulary of 650 words on entering the first grade is considered necessary to accomplishment of this objective.
- II. Administration: The program will be a part of the regular program for each elementary school unit, under the direction and supervision of the elementary school principal, with accounting by the principal to the Director of Pupil Accounting. Each principal will develop the program for the students of his school zone, select the teachers with the approval of the superintendent, and meet the needs of the program as apply to the school unit for which he is responsible. It will be necessary for the principal to line-up complete parent support for the program and to limit enrollment to those students who can and will attend regularly for the entire period of the program. The school unit principal will be responsible for evaluative reports and other requirements of the Texas Education Agency, including the program application for the individual school unit.
- III. Pupil Eligibility
- A. The student must reach the age of six on or before September 1 of the ensuing school year and be eligible for initial enrollment in the first grade.
- B. The student is one who does not speak and understand the common English language words necessary for normal progress in the first grade.
- C. The student is one with whose parents the principal has developed an understanding that will assure regular attendance for the child and home encouragement in English speaking.
- IV. Instructional Units
- A. Teaching units will be employed on the basis of one teacher for each student group organized by the principal in such a way as to guarantee that an ADA of 20 will be maintained for the period of the program.
- B. The program will be operated by the principal and teacher for a minimum of 40 days, 8:00 A.M. - 12:00 P.M., with a minimum of three hours in direct classroom instruction and 30 minutes in supervised playground activities involving use of English.
- C. A standard first grade classroom with appropriate instructional facilities will be used.
- D. Suitable materials and supplies will be provided for the teacher and pupils.
- E. The teacher will be a regular teacher experienced in teaching non-English speaking children, especially selected for skill in developing an oral English vocabulary of usage and comprehension.
- F. The teacher will be paid on the basis of state salary schedule, half-time, not exceeding \$200 per month, provided an ADA of 20 is maintained.
- V. Supervisory Service
- A. Supervision will be by the school unit principal.
- B. A classroom teacher, trained and experienced in the teaching of oral English to non-English speaking children will be named by the Superintendent to work with the selected teachers, develop word lists, teaching techniques, and instructional materials especially designed for this project.
- VI. Organizational Steps
- A. Census-takers will attempt the following:
1. Establish with the parent the desirability of giving the student a "good start" in the English language before he enters school.
 2. Make a rough estimate of whether the particular six-year-old may be expected as a result of home background to enter school with a vocabulary of English usage and comprehension amounting to approximately 300 words. If so, an (E) is to be recorded on census form in front of the child's name. This will be general information for principals, but will not have high validity.
- B. At an appropriate time, the pupil accounting office will submit a list of zoned six-year-old students to each principal.
- C. A letter will be mailed from the superintendent's office informing the parent of the pre-school English program and requesting any parent interested to contact the school principal, who will discuss the program further and have the parent complete a form to be furnished certifying that if a class group is set up, his child will attend regularly for the full period of the class.

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- D. If the number of commitments from parents is such that a T.E.A. reimbursable unit is assured, the superintendent will employ a teacher for the unit. If the number is not sufficient, an effort will be made to include the children in a unit in another school in the system.
- VII. It must be recognized by all concerned that the explicit purpose of the pre-school English class is to develop a vocabulary of usage and comprehension which enables the student to make normal progress in school, that is, complete the first grade after one full year of public school attendance. The accomplishment of this purpose will require:
- A. Parent commitment and support, obtained by the principal in conference with the parent, with certification form signed by the parent.
 - B. An instructional program designed and carried out toward the stated goals.
 - C. Non-enrollment by the principal of students who, because of non-attendance or other factors, can not reasonably be expected to attain the goals of the program. Enrollment of students for whom the stated goals are not practical or conduct of the program toward other goals will place the District in the position of conducting a kindergarten, recreational, or baby-sitting program for one segment of its scholastic population to the exclusion of other segments of the population.
- VIII. That which follows is an interpretation, but we feel, nevertheless, that it should be stated. Four conditions have caused this program to be enacted as law:
- ✓ A. The actual fact that many parents can not and/or do not give their children an English language background which will enable them to make normal progress in the first grade.
 - ☆ B. The tendency of some educators to categorize all such students and arbitrarily require that the students spend two years in the first grade, conducting the educational program in such a way that those who can make normal progress have no opportunity to do so.
 - ☆ C. Along with the concept of arbitrarily holding children two years in the first grade so they can be "good" second graders, a lack of emphasis after the first year on continuous development of oral language usage and comprehension in all grades, two through twelve. By strict adherence to the two-year concept, the Spanish-speaking student may become a "good" second grader, but he will not become a "good" fourth grader or seventh grader unless there is continuing emphasis on language development in all its forms.
 - D. A tendency, seldom found nowadays, for Spanish-speaking students without adequate English language background to be rejected because of the special teaching problems they may present.

Respectfully,

Ohland Morton

Ohland Morton
Superintendent

T. S. Pickens

Thomas S. Pickens
Assistant Superintendent

OM/TSP:wbw

cc; All Principals
All Elem. Sch. Teachers
Mrs. Magee
Mrs. Morgan